from other clubs, didn't make me feel better about myself. Reading that they might want me was reassuring at a time when it seemed like United didn't. But the speculation was getting in the way. I wanted to get on with playing. I'm sure the manager wasn't happy about the distraction, either. Maybe that's why it felt as if I was involved in my own private Arctic. The mood—for me, at least—before the Charlton game was intense in all the wrong ways.

I scored the first goal in a game we had to win to keep ahead of Arsenal. The shot took a deflection, going in at a strange angle. My reaction wasn't the obvious one, either. Rattling around in my head had been the question: was this my last game at Old Trafford for United? A lot of other people had been asking the same that week. As I wheeled away towards the supporters, the instinctive joy that comes with a goal collided with the thought that I might never be doing this again. The celebration stuttered. I was happy to score but choking back tears at the same time. We beat Charlton 4–1. It turned out to be enough to win us the League, although we didn't know that until the following day when Arsenal lost to Leeds.

Meanwhile, we celebrated another win with the United supporters: if this was going to be a farewell to Old Trafford, I was happy there'd been a goal for them to remember me by. I found myself standing next to Gary and feeling very sad as I looked around the place I'd got used to calling home. He leaned over. He asked me what was wrong. I told him:

'They're having talks with other clubs.'

Gary just didn't want to think it was true. I know we're best mates. I also know how much he loves Manchester United. He wouldn't ever have wanted me and the club not to be together. After I'd changed and had something to drink in the lounge, I took Brooklyn out on the field for a kickabout. Old Trafford was empty, sunshine still creeping over the roof of the stand. If I was going to go to pieces, that would have been the moment: the place looked beautiful, still echoing with the voices of the 60,000 fans who'd been jammed in there an hour earlier. Brooklyn just wanted to play, though. He didn't want his dad getting emotional on him with an open goal waiting. It was a bittersweet afternoon. I'm glad I finished it in the company of my boy. I was starting to feel resigned to my fate.

And then, one last time, it all changed again. Was it just the relief of winning the title? Did we all relax, including the boss? For a week, never mind the gossip in the papers, all seemed well in the world. During training, I felt like I was welcome, like I belonged, for the first time in months, the boss